

'Eco-Marxmelodramatics' in Some Select Nigerian Plays from the Niger Delta.

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Abstract

The geographical terrain of Nigeria known as the Niger Delta is a space known for violence connected to the exploration and exploitation of the rich deposit of crude oil which in the main, at least for quite some decades has become the main stay of Nigerian foreign earnings. The feeling of the dwellers has been that there is a tilt in the balance of the resource management to their disadvantage as their source of livelihood is taken away from them without commensurate compensation, reason being that, their surroundings are left degraded, devastated, exploited, plundered and polluted to say the least. Hence, they live life in abject poverty, dejection, desolation, and absence or near absence of basic social amenities. This argument is why some of the youth leaders of this region take laws into their hands after exhausting other non violent strategies to get the attention of the government and their exploiters by kidnapping oil workers, vandalizing oil pipelines and others, leading most times to violent confrontations between them and law enforcement agencies. This has not gone down well with the growth and developmental drive of Nigeria. Fortified with this justification, the study therefore attempts analysis of some Nigerian play texts with this thematic interrogation, and equally zeroing on Eco-'Marxmelodramatic' theory with the view to navigating a path that will dunc the consequential throwbacks from this ugly menace. Consequently, this treatise adopts a stance of dialogic shifting of grounds by both parties and abiding by resolutions reached to engender a non frictional social relationship.

Key words: Eco-drama, Marxism, Melodrama, Niger Delta, Plays

Introduction

We are in an era globally where the human race is terribly threatened not only

with massive but seemingly untamable tragic disasters at a very high frequency swift. They come most times with a speed that leaves the human race helpless, so much that their negative effects on the human race are unimaginable in the number of; hectares of farm land lost leading to the destruction of farm produce, infrastructures, wreckages of the lives and habitats of wild life and the gross loss human lives. Whatever angles any one may want to weigh the magnitude of their aftermath effects; it runs into thousands, million and billion of naira in terms of monetary calculation talk more of the human resource. This is certainly not palatable for the economic and political well being of any country under this unfavourable experience. This Akowe, Achor and Idakwo, Samson strengthen:

The world over is experiencing variant degrees of challenges ranging from economic recession and depression, terrorism, humanitarian concerns, political violence, environmental degradation, tsunamis, climatic change, drought to mention but a few. Therefore, the resultant effects of these cataclysms have left and are still leaving its trail of poverty, loss of lives and homes, and host of others on humanity.

Be that as it may, these disasters; either human or nature made, at whatever magnitude and rapidity and however it leaves humanity perplexed, it never leaves it completely without mankind seeking an immediate remedy or a way to forestall future reoccurrence. This stride is why scholars have thrown their weight behind the quest for an interdisciplinary scholarship for cross fertilization of ideas with the view of taking humanity away from the perpetual dungeon of both natural and manmade calamities, ravaging both human and non human world because, "environmental education is a multidiscursive field. It is a space of both struggle and opportunity for the reconstruction of a web of relations between humans and the environment and with each other Uzoji, (19)". To further buttress this claim, Mbachaga says; "an ecological vision in the reading and writing of literary texts becomes imperative because there is a serious threat to the ecosphere and our responses towards creating a consciousness regarding nature awareness of what is silenced or hidden through deliberate abuse of the natural world or through omission that result in ecological crisis across the globe (3)". It is this feat in multi-disciplinary research which Akowe, Achor and Idakwo, Samson vent claiming that "any literary work, stage performances, films and others that are concerned with the

business of engaging its readers/ audience to go into critical thinking, with the view to ensuring that they take actions either individually and (more importantly) collectively to reconsider their relationship with nature towards striking an interdependent eco-human balance falls under .this umbrella body called Eco-Criticism (21)". What's more, it is this Eco-Criticism that has led to theory of eco literature with its vagaries of eco criticism in the order of; eco theatre, eco poetics, eco drama; eco metaphor etc. On this premise, there is a nuptial configuration between sciences and literature, (specifically speaking between Biology and Drama). While ecology is biologically inclined, trying to explain the social relationship that exists in the ecosystem between living organisms and their immediate environment, in the same vein, drama draws its raw materials from the social goings on between human beings (living organisms) and within the space where they find themselves.

Additionally, research has it that mankind in its relationship with its non human world has not and is not dealing fairly with the non human earth. It is observed that in human quest to satisfy their needs, they extend this frontier to inordinate, insatiable acquisition of selfish aggrandizement of wealth and over bloated luxurious living, with reckless degradation, exploitation, exploration, pilfering, plundering and pollution of the non human neighbours leaving it helplessly ripped, raped and deserted. Uzoji again, quoting McLaren supports this claim that; "globing up the global life world in the quest for an endless accumulation of surplus value, has produced some world – historical excretory excesses turning the world into a global toilet of toxic waste... (20)". To supplementary accentuate this certainty, Adesoke, Adefolaju avers:

[M]an has over exploited the earth's resources to his own injury. This has led to fouling or bastardization of natural resources such as water, tress air, soil, animals and aquatic creatures which has in return led to the ruination of man and his habitat as survival is made extremely difficult. (65)

With this kind of score card where natural habitats, state of existing of living and nonliving things are grossly affected, thereby reducing maximally their productive capacities that would have benefitted mankind, it makes survival a near impossible reality. Take for instance the water ways, once it is polluted by industrial waste, this singular act could extinct the entire aquatic lives of a region. If this is left unchecked, it could lead to loss of job as people of this area

are majorly aquatic farmers, absence of jobs could lead to hunger and remember a hungry man is an angry man. Coincidentally, the Niger Delta area of Nigeria covers the location that houses states like; Akwa Ibom, Bayelsa, Cross River, Delta, Edo and Rivers, which "stretches over a continuous rainforest characterized by beautiful patterns of creeks, streams and rivers. It is especially rich in palm oil, timber and crude oil... (Ushie, 3)". He further asserts also that; "prior to the coming of the whites, the various ethnic groups of the Niger Delta were predominantly farmers, fishermen, hunters and tapers... (3)". But since the exploration and exploitation of the crude oil in this region, Tugbokorowie and Ogo-Raphael quoting Owabukeruye affirm this has "impacted disastrously on the socio-physical environment of the Niger Delta oil bearing communities massively threatening the subsistent peasant economy and the environment and hence the entire livelihood and basic survival of the people (114)". Consequently, it is that "region within the Nigerian political and geographical set up...that suffers monumental social injustice, political marginalization and economic alienation in spite of its abundance natural resources (Omoko, 2)". Hence, "the resultant effect of this state of affairs is not only the proliferation of the militant movements... but also the continuous poverty, loss of lives and enormous resources, daily cases of abduction or hostage taking etc... (Akoh, Ameh, 201)". This kind of concern readily becomes the raw material with which playwrights bogged with these unpleasant social transactions going in the Niger Delta, craft their literatures so as to tame its excesses or put a stop (if possible) to it, for the overall well being of the people of the affected region.

Theoretical Framework

As earlier mentioned, the term Eco Criticism, as a literary domain which tries to high lights the relationship that exist between literature and its physical space from which they emanates, thrusting to the fore of discourse environmental challenges, dwelling heavily on the devastating effects of human activities on its immediate environment and its reprisal repercussion on humans, originates from the United State of America around 1978 when Michael P. Branch quoted in Ajima, Maria traced this concept which was earlier on known as "The Study of Nature" after William Rueckert presented an article titled "Literature and Ecology". Its adoption in the year 1979 at the Western Literature Association meeting held at Couer di Alene was made public. It is in this forum that Cheryl Glotfelty reviewed the term and urged for its adoption. (35). Cheryl Glotfelty in

her review looks at the inter connection between nature and culture at a critical stance, which has one foot in literature and the other one in land, as a theoretical discourse, it negotiates between the human and the non human... Eco critics and theorists alike ask question like; what role does the physical setting plays in the plot of this novel? Are the values expressed in this play consistent with ecological wisdom? How does our metaphor of the land influence the way we treat it? Can we characterize nature writing into genres? In what ways is environmental crisis seeping into contemporary and popular cultures? What bearing might the science of ecology have on literary study? How is science its self open to literary analysis? What cross fertilization is possible between literary studies and environmental discourse in related discipline history, philosophy, psychology, art history and ethics? (Mbachaga, 2).

Marxist theory

Marxist literary theory or criticism... draws its foundation... from the writing of the German social critic and philosopher, Karl Heinrich Marx. Even though Marx did not explicitly establish a link between his ideas and literature, literary theorists and critics have over the years particularly during the 20th century utilized Marx's philosophical assumptions as enunciated in such works as *German Ideology* (1845), *The Communist Manifesto*, (1848) *Das Capital* (1867) to create approaches of textual analysis that focus on the study of the relationship between a text and the society that reads it (Bresslar in Inyang and Ime, 96). According to an internet source, the writing of Karl Marx did not make much impact into organizational theory in the US until in the 1970s... The Marxist approach began largely as a critique of the human relations school which argues that organizational structures are not rational for performing work in the most efficient manner; rather, they are power system designed to maximize control and profits... Marx saw that the social relations of production in society as the primary source of class stratification and conflict (<http://faculty.babson.edu/krollag.org..site/encyclop/marx..theory.html>). Consequently, “engineering the desire to seek redress or force change through social activities, movements or violence as the case may be (Inyang and Ime, 96)”.

The problem is not in the individual characteristics of the workers but the inevitable consequences of their position in the labour system. Once labourers no longer owned the tools of production, they

were alienated from the dominant values of the society (<http://faculty.babson.edu/krollag.org..site/encyclop/marx..theory.html>). Besides, “as philosophical plan and system that aims to engineer change in the society, Marxism provide an immediate understanding of reality, society and individual by examining the social, political and economic and cultural circumstances (Bresslar in Inyang and Ime, 96)”.

Melodrama theory

According to Edwin Wilson, during the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, one of the most popular forms of theatre was melodrama. The word, which comes from Greek, means “music drama” or “song drama”. He further stresses that its modern form was introduced by the French in the eighteenth century and applied to plays which had background music of the kind we hear in movies; ominous chords underscoring scene of suspense and lyrical music underscoring love scene. Among other effects, for which it generally strives, is fright or horror. It has been said that melodrama speaks to the paranoia in us; the fear that something is pursuing us or that disaster is about to override us. Melodrama brings this fear to life; we see people stalked or terrorized, or innocent victims tortured, murder mysteries... it stresses suspense, danger, and close brushes with disasters. Melodrama features exaggerated characters and events arranged to create horror or suspense to present a didactic argument for some political, moral or social point of view.

In a nut shell, it is this assemblage of the above intellectual configurations that gives backings to this entire article claiming that, the texts under study fall within the purview of eco drama, Marxism and melodramatic aesthetics which we coin as '*Eco-Marxistmelodramatics*'.

Play synopses

The play *Little Drops...* by Ahmed Yerima relays a pathetic gory story of an imaginary Gbaramaramatu kingdom, sets in the Niger Delta plagued with environmental disasters and youth restiveness. Hence, the confrontation between agitators and the Government Joint Task Force, leaving behind score of loss of lives and the wanton destruction of property. First, the community was under attack because of the civil war that claimed the lives of Memekeize's husband and her two sons while fishing. Now she lives her lonely life by the river bank.

Again, it is the fight between the government and the youth, who are protesting against marginalization, because the international oil companies pollute the water ways and land, depriving them of their source of livelihood without commensurate compensation. In the face off, Ovievie, a leader of one of the many fractional factions of the agitators is killed and his wife Mukume is raped severally. She then runs away from home to take refuge temporarily at river bank at Memekezie's shed. There and then comes Azue, the king's wife, whose husband the youth beheads, on the account of betrayal between his people and the government. Unknown to her, son, the prince, whom she thought she has escaped with has been shoot and dies. In the same seam, we see Bonuwo, a school teacher, running for her dear life relaying to Memekezie, Mekume and Azue her ordeal of how her forty one students have been killed in the cause of the face off and now, the parents of those children are after her life, and then also comes, Kuru, the leader of the youth, responsible for the death of the king. He have been shoot on the thigh unknown to him, he comes threatening the women at the river bank and slumps, he begs for help and he is rescued and helps to rescue the other women across the river to begin a new life all over again.

The swamp Dwellers by Wole Soyinka reenacts the saga of the impoverished peasants living in the swamps. The play opens with the family of Makuri and his wife Alu, lamenting over the return of their son, Igwezu from the city who could not wait a minute before rushing to his farm land that has been ravaged by the flood, that has taken over the whole community. There and then, comes a blind Beggar from the far north, in search of greener pasture since his own community has been taken over by drought and attacks of locusts on their crops each time there is rainfall at all. He relays all that under the hospitality of his host, Makuri and Alu. Hence, he has come to look for land to farm and not to beg for alms. Makuri tells him the land available for farming belongs to the serpent, while the ones available to the rest of community members are flood prone and polluted by oil spillage, being the reason for massive exodus of young men to the cities.

It is in anticipation of their son's return that Kadiye, the chief priest of the Serpent, pays the Makuris a visit for a haircut. Kadiye prefers a cut from Igwezu. It is discovered that Igwezu before travelling to the city with his wife, had carry out all the necessary sacrifices to the Serpent through the priest for

fruitful marriage and pumper harvest, yet while in town, he lost his wife to his own brother and his crops to the flood. In anger he reminds the priest of his exploitative tendencies and hence in the course of shaving his beard, dare to slit his chin in retaliation.

Eco-Marxmelodramatic Aesthetics in the Plays

The two plays under review metaphorically embody issues bordering on ecological concern. Hence, they can be categorically placed under eco critical genre called eco drama, because eco criticism “takes an earth centred approach to literary criticism” (Afolabi, Taiwo, 85). This is so, because “the relevance of eco criticism to modern day literary and theatrical expositions cannot be over emphasized in the present global challenges and concern” (Eben, Adeseke, 58). *The Little Drops..* and *The Swamps Dwellers* thrust to the fore, the socio-economic and cultural relationship that exist between human and the non human world, the throw backs from this relationship and its relational consequences on the overall well being on the humans. At this juncture,, this study shall dwell on the activities of humans in the area of oil spillage and gas flaring which has been the fate of the Niger Delta ever since the exploration and exploitation of oil began in this region and how that has altered the ecological balance between the human and non human environment as captured in the duo texts.

(In *The Little Drops...*).

Meme: See where I live. My family were fishermen before the other war took. And I was the best fish seller in this part of the creek, but now the water is polluted. Oil kills the fish before we get there... (61-62).

(In *the Swamp Dwellers*)

Makuri: Much damage? Not a grain was saved not one tuber in the soil... and what the flood left behind as poisoned by the oil in the swamp... (16-17).

From the reading above, the texts through their characters further strengthen the argument that “eco critics encourage others to think seriously about the relationship of human to nature about the ethical and aesthetic dilemmas posed by the environmental crisis and about how language and literature transmit values with profound ecological implications” (Sunusi, Shehu, 98). It therefore, meets our requirements then to say that, there a mutual relationship between eco criticism and other academic fields of study,

considering the global outcry in creating ecological consciousness about the neighbourliness of both human and the non human world that co exist, pointing to the fact that the human environment plays a substantive role in sustaining the humans and how non human world needs humans for protecting and maintaining it. Thus, this is what these two playwrights strives to achieve.

Moreover, the two drama texts under interrogation poke at the upshot effects of human indiscriminate dispositions towards nature among the Niger Delta communities affected by human reckless economic and social practices, leading to a high rate of unemployment and severe hunger. Remember one of the early warning signals of violence is severe hunger. Therefore, when once hunger is left to fester for a very long time, it transforms in to aggression, which leads to agitation and if not well managed, it translates into confrontation or violence. This is the reason why violence seems to be prominent in the Niger Delta. The position here is reinforced through the characters below:

(In the Swamp Dwellers)

Makuri: He came for his crops. Now he knows they have been ruined by the floods, he'll be running back to the city.

Alu: It's a lot down for him... coming all the way back and finding no harvest.

Makuri: (Flaring.) But you haven't journeyed three days only to be cheated of your crops... (11)

(In The Little Drops...).

Meme: See where I live. My family were fishermen before the other war took. And I was the best fish seller in this part of the creek, but now the water is polluted. Oil kills the fish before we get there... (61-62).

The discovery and reckless exploration and exploitation of crude oil in this part of the country, has helped to ravage the huge deposits of the forest and aquatic lives and this has tremendously affected the survival tendencies of the Niger Deltans, who were predominantly farmers, hunters, fishermen and what have you. Now it is on record that the Niger Delta when compared to other regions has poorest score card of "poor economic, Social and infrastructural status. The gory experience of the substandard/insufficient healthcare facilities, deficient/inadequate basic secondary education, lack of portable drinking

water, raising cases of insecurity of life and properties and bad roads confront the residents makes life most miserable (Olatayo, Isijola 118)".

Going further, even though violence is not an option in this research, depravation births aggression as people begin to feel that certain factor or persons are responsible for why certain goals could not be attained. This claim Wole and Ahmed dare to bring to the burner of investigation relaying thus:

(In *The Little Drops...*)

Kuru: All we are asking for is the development of the Niger Delta which has a population of twenty eight million.

Azue: Twenty-eight million?

Kuru: Yes and we are the owners of the raw materials, but we don't have a say in the sharing. Because there is poverty and high unemployment.

Mukume: The youth. How about the youth?

Kuru: There is frustration among the youths, this is what draws them to violence. They need a sense of belonging and they shall be less attracted to violence. (62-63)

(In *The Swamp Dwellers*)

IGWEJU: And ever since I began to till soil did I not the soil its due? Did I not bring the first of the lentils to the shrine and pour the oil on the alter?

KADIYE: Regularly.

IGWEZU: And when Kadiye blessed my marriage, and tied heaven-made knot, did he not promise a long life? Did he not promise children? Did he not promise happiness? (38)

Behind every insurgency in the Niger Delta there is a motivation in the guise of aggression, which plays out in the attacks unleashed against multinational oil companies, occasioned by non compliance to agreement reached between these parties; the relinquishing of the land for exploration, so that they can be provided with employment and the basic facilities that will make life favourable to community members. These promises made, have never been the experience of these people as their community leaders help to exploit, oppress, suppress, marginalizes their own in connivance with the multi-national oil companies. This high level of effrontery, to abuse and marginalize the people, with relative ease is because the leaders collaborate with corporations for their own selfish interests.

This naturally brings this discourse to the Karl Marx postulation on the socio-economic and political matrix between the upper and the lower (the haves and have not). According to this leaning, the gap that exists between these classes is a product of exploitation because of the capitalistic propensities of the bourgeoisie. In addition, this gap will continue to burgeon as long as the lower class permits it. For Marx there is the need for the exploited to rise to the occasion by force to change the narrative even if it means wielding arms to forestall further exploitation. This is how these texts express Marxist's pose:

(In *The Swamp Dwellers*)

IGWEZU: If I slew the fatted calf, Kadiye, do you think the land might breathe again? If I slew all the cattle in the land and sacrifice every measure of goodness, would it make any difference to our lives, Kadiye? Would it make any difference to our fates?
(*the servant runs out*)

KADIYE: (In a choking voice) Makuri, speak to your son...

BEGGER: Master... master...

(*Igwezu suddenly shaves off the final smear of the lather with a rapid stroke which makes Kadiye flinch. Releases and throws the razor on the table*)

(*Kadiye scrambles up at once, tearing the cloth from his neck, makes for the door*)

KADIYE: (*Panting.*) you shall pay for this... I shall make pay for this... Do you think you can make an ass out of Kadiye?.. Do you think you can pour your sacrilege into my ears with impunity?

IGWEZU: Go quickly Kadiye (*sinks into the seat*). And the next time you wish to celebrate the stopping of the rain, do not choose a barber whose harvest rots beneath the mire.

KADIYE: You will pay, I swear it... you will pay for this.

(*Flings off the sheet and goes out*) (39).

(In *The Little Drops*...)

KURU: ... The oil companies are playing games with us. They think they are smart. There are some in government and high places who believe the Niger Delta people be taught a lesson, so each law is against us. Each law is without us. Even our big men are covered with too much tea drinking that they forget the true course (sic) of their people. But they shall see. We shall destroy everything... everything... everything. Total break up! (63)

Drawing some deductions from the dialogue above, will review the frustration of the youth in the Niger Delta, so much that they have to voice out their despair in other to upset an order that will not listen to the cry of their plights and will prefer that they are perpetually kept in the worst environmental degradation “while these oil companies repatriates their loots to their home countries and the people suffer the after effects of oil spillages (Essi, David 198)”. From Kuru's conversation, they have been fooled enough and it is time to wage war against this injustice. Hence the battle line that has been drawn and the raging upheaval between them and the oil companies with their own conniving leaders. In the case of Igwezu, in his frustrated and agitated stances, he dares to confront Kadiye, the chief priest, of the serpent with some salient questions “such as why should people always do their work and floods disrupt them? Why is it that the deity – the serpent [*whom they make sacrifices through the chief*] could not repel the floods? Why is it that the priest is insisting on more sacrifices in the aftermath of the calamity? (Essi, David 200).” (Emphasis mine). With no substantive respond from the chief, he tears his face with the shaving razor making Kadiye to run for his dear life. Igwezu sitting on the seat Kadiye jumped up from symbolizes dethronement of an oppressive authority.

Lastly, we shall try to discuss the melodramatics canon inherent the plays under survey. In our assertion, Wole and Ahmed present an intellectual buffet for melodramatic model for interrogative consumption in line with Edwin Willson's opinion that; the audience are drawn into action; the issues are clear cut and there is a strong delineation of right and wrong; the characters are clearly recognized as good or bad; the actions are exaggerated, with the main character always living in danger an the edge of calamity and there is a strong suspense.

In the two texts are *dramatis personae* that have real resemblance of the exactitude of the people of the Niger Delta communities, who face similar environmental disasters and are hopeless and helpless, which pitiable situations are mostly orchestrated by natural and human disasters in collaboration with multinational oil companies and their leaders. A pathetic saga as such should naturally attract audience's sympathy because, “the characters and their problems are credible, thus when something devastating happens... we are meant to take it seriously (Wilson 247)”. Secondly, the issues brought on the table of discourse from the texts under scrutiny are crystal clear cut. It is the case of exploration and exploitation of the crude oil resource,

leading to unimaginable calamity on the majority of the affected communities without commensurate compensation, strongly delineating what is right and wrong. Ovivie and Makuri, character in *The Little Drops...* and In *The Swamps Dwellers* respectively have this to say; “a saint? No. there is no way one could seat on the fence. No. you could not watch the world exploit your people. With so much neglect, you could not turn your face away. We all felt a sense of duty to fight (48)”, “Much damage? Not a grain was saved not one tuber in the soil... and what the flood left behind as poisoned by the oil in the swamp... (16-17)”.

Thirdly, these texts relay huge class division between good and bad characters. For instance, Kadiye, oil companies, community leaders fall under the category of the oppressors, while Igwezu, Memekize, Azue, Kuru, Mukume etc are portrayed as the oppressed. Fourthly, both plays capture uncertain incidents of events of 'what happens next' question, from the beginning to the end of the plays. In *The Little...* we see Mukume running to the river bank after been raped severally, going to face another rape section only to find out that Memekize is a female (10). Kuru comes on scene threatening to kill everyone at the river bank, sooner than ever, he slumps having been shot on his thigh, there and then he becomes the hunted (51-57). While in *The Swamps...* Igwezu is back from the city, his crops are destroyed, now he dares the undareable. His father warns him, for that could spell doom for him, because of the anger of the Serpent's chief priest, the god of the community. He shuns his father's advice and slits Kadiye's face. This is how Wole captures the incidents; (*Igwezu suddenly shaves of the final smear of the lather with a rapid stroke which makes Kadiye flinch. Releases and throws the razor on the table*). (*Kadiye srambles up at once, tearing the cloth from his neck, makes for the door*)

IGWEZU: Go quickly Kadiye (*sinks into the seat*). And the next time you wish to the celebrate the stopping of the rain, do not choose a barber whose harvest rots beneath the mire. (39)

Finally, the events captured in the fourth point above, creates in the play a suspenseful experiences both to closet and public audience. Suffice then to say that, the chronological arrangements of events in the plays are action parked, emotionally indulges the audience to sympathize with the characters that are left helpless, hopeless, defenseless by that power that be as they stand to fight for their rights. This singular act leaves their lives in perpetual danger and near death experiences even as captured from excerpts of the preceding paragraph.

Finally, “melodrama usually ends in either one or two ways; or the victims are maimed or murdered... or, after a series of dangerous episodes, they are rescued” (Wilson, 240). For instance, Memekizie losing her husband and two sons (52), Mukume her husband and dignity haven been raped severally (48), Azue, the queen her husband, the king and her son the prince (25), Bonuwo her forty-one students (39) and Kuru at the verge of death haven been shot on the thigh by the Government Joint Task Force, leaving two bullets lodged in there, is rescued by those he threatened to kill few minutes before. (Ahmed, 50; 66). While in *The Swamps*... Igwezu, even when his father had warned him not to dare the chief priest, haven lost his entire savings to the flood, dares him not minding the outcome (Wole, 41). These characters all lost something dear to them yet there were rescued to begin a new life.

As we conclude, the research reveals that presently, the human space suffers severe human and non human disasters with all its vagaries. In all of this, intellectuals have not given up in their pursuits for a friendlier and better ecological balance. It is this crave that has given birth to eco criticism with all its variance, which eco drama is one. The two texts reviewed; push to the platform of academic discourse ecological concerns, mirroring the social, economic and political dimensions to this appraisal leading the Marxist matrix. The melodramatic milieu to this study is also not left out even though its concept, which initially connotes a dramatic presentation that is heavily laden with musical embellishment, has over time become a domain of tragic drama where the tragic hero/heroine, in his state of near perfection in character disposition fights for either for the general good of others or to uphold certain cultural virtue, or to deconstruct certain social structure that is detrimental to the overall well being of society but is met with a strong resistance from the constructors of such an order. Hence, in asserting his/her position is flawed by one little weakness strong enough to bring him/her to doom's day. Yet, haven suffered the consequence(s) of his/her effrontery to question the status quo, still lives triumphantly. It is this academic drive that births the reconstruction of the *Eco-Marxmelodramatics* in this study.

Recommendation

A country at crisis cannot achieve developmental strides it deserves and at a stipulated time. Then if Nigeria desires to move out of its present economic conundrum in order to reclaim its place in the African and global world order,

then the present administration under president Ahmed Bola Tinibu (even though his election is still being contested at the Supreme Court), has to raise to the occasion in ensuring that the agreement reached by the two parties (Multinational Oil Companies and their host communities) is upheld in towering inviolability, and any community leader found culpable should be dealt with as stipulated by the law, regardless of their social, economic and political, religious and ethnic backgrounds. This will definitely go along way so reduce some of the perennial environmental and agitation crises in the Niger Delta.

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